

AP Japanese Language & Culture: The Complete Exam Guide

The new project-based exam explained: the presentation and Q&A, story narration and email response, listening and reading, and 10 practice questions in Japanese.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.



~2 hrs

fully digital exam
in Bluebook

55+4

multiple-choice +
free-response tasks

35%

of your score comes
from your project

72–75%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01	The exam at a glance	2	06	10 traps that cost points	7
02	Listening & reading	3	07	Your study roadmap to May	8
03	The 6 themes & the project	4	08	10 practice questions	9
04	The free-response tasks	5	09	Answer key & explanations	11
05	Anatomy of a full-credit answer	6	10	Scores & exam-day checklist	12



THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Your project, plus skills

The exam now centers on a research project you complete during the year about a Japanese-speaking community. Your score (1–5) combines speaking about that project, writing, and listening and reading.

20%

Project presentation

15%

Project Q&A

15%

Story + email

50%

Multiple choice • 55 Q

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
Q1 • Project presentation	20% of score 3 min prep + 3 min speaking	Deliver a spoken presentation in Japanese answering the project prompt, using your Personalized Project Reference (PPR) .
Q2 • Project Q&A	15% of score 4 questions • 40 s each	Answer four pre-recorded questions about your project research.
Q3–4 • Story narration + email	7.5% + 7.5% of score 30 minutes total	Story narration: write a story based on a series of pictures. Email response: reply to an email from a friend or community member.
II • Multiple choice	50% of score ~65 min 55 questions	Listening: 25 questions (25 min, 25%) on audio sources • Reading: 30 questions (40 min, 25%) on print texts.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

BEFORE EXAM DAY

Submit your PPR by late April

Your **Personalized Project Reference** is a structured outline of your research and sources. Submit it in the AP Digital Portfolio by the late-April deadline; you can see it during the presentation.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.

SECTION II

02 Listening & reading

55 questions in about 65 minutes. Listening questions use authentic audio such as interviews, podcasts and announcements; reading questions use articles, ads, charts and literary texts.

25

listening questions on audio sources

30

reading questions on print sources

50%

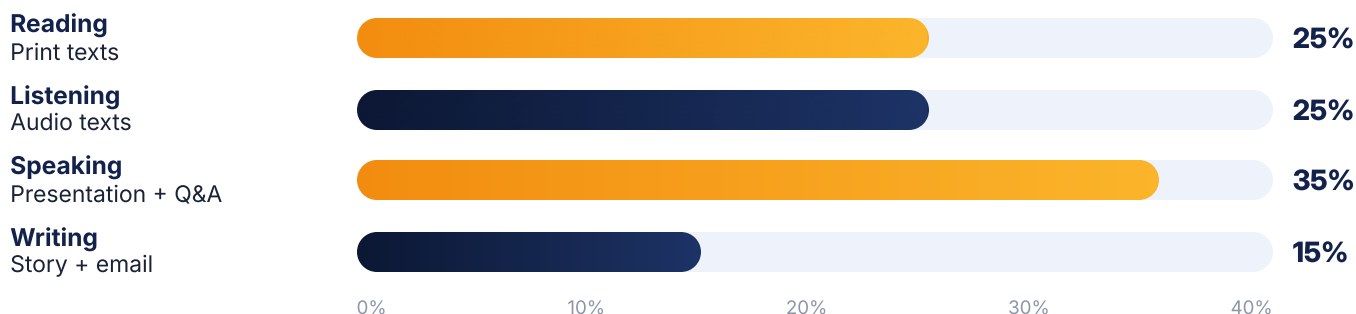
of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

◆ How your score is built

Share of the total exam score for each skill.

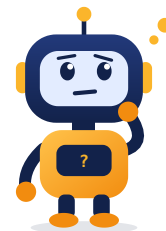


What this means for your study time: Speaking about your project is the single biggest part of the exam (35%). Listening and reading together are half, so daily exposure to authentic audio and texts matters.

◆ Strategies that work on this section

- ◆ **Preview the questions** before each audio plays, so you know what to listen for.
- ◆ **Take short notes** while listening: names, numbers, opinions and the main idea.
- ◆ **Read the introduction line** of each text; it tells you the source and purpose.
- ◆ **Don't translate word for word.** Use context to infer meaning of unknown words.
- ◆ **Watch for paraphrase.** Correct answers rarely repeat the text's exact words.
- ◆ **Never leave a blank.** There is no penalty for guessing.

Listen to **Japanese podcasts or news** for 10 minutes a day. It trains your ear for natural speed.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 6 themes & the project

Course content is organized into six themes. Your project connects research to one of them, using authentic sources in Japanese.

THEME

1

Families & Communities

Explore: family values, traditions and how communities are changing in Japanese-speaking communities.

THEME

2

Language & Culture

Explore: how language, media and technology shape identity and cultural expression.

THEME

3

Art & Creativity

Explore: how art, music and literature reflect a community's history and values.

THEME

4

Science & Technology

Explore: how scientific and technological change affects daily life and society.

THEME

5

Contemporary Life

Explore: education, work, leisure, popular culture and changing lifestyles.

THEME

6

Global Contexts

Explore: how global issues such as the environment, migration and health affect communities.

◆ The course project, step by step

1 • Research

Investigate the project prompt using authentic Japanese-language sources.

2 • Build your PPR

Create your Personalized Project Reference: a structured outline of findings and sources.

3 • Submit

Upload the PPR to the AP Digital Portfolio by the late-April deadline.

4 • Present

On exam day, present for 3 minutes and answer 4 questions about your research.

SECTION I

04 The free-response tasks

Two spoken tasks about your project, then two written tasks in 30 minutes.

Presentation 20%

Q&A 15%

Story 7.5%

Email 7.5%

Free response = 50% of your AP score

Q1

Project presentation

3 min prep • 3 min speaking

Answer the project prompt using what you learned. Organize clearly: introduction, main findings with examples from your sources, and a conclusion.

Practice timing: aim for 2:45–3:00 so you use the full time.

Q2

Project Q&A

4 questions • 40 seconds each

Respond to four recorded questions that ask you to explain, extend or reflect on your research.

Answer directly in the first sentence, then add one detail or example.

Q3

Story narration

Written • with Q4 in 30 min

Write a story based on a series of pictures, with a beginning, middle and end.

Use time words and connectors to link the pictures.

Q4

Email response

Written • with Q3 in 30 min

Read an email and write a reply that responds to every question and request in it.

Use an appropriate greeting, register and closing.

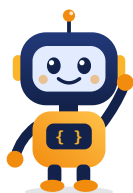
◆ Presentation: your 6 minutes

Review PPR
1 min

Plan points
2 min

Present
3 min

Use the preparation time to choose two or three key findings and an example for each.



Use **linking words** and a range of tenses. Variety in your speaking raises your score.

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

05

Anatomy of a strong presentation

Here is a short sample of a strong project presentation opening, annotated to show what earns points.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (project presentation style): How do different generations support each other in a Japanese community? Use what you learned in your research.

Sample presentation opening

- ① 今日は、日本の地域で若い人とお年寄りがどのように助け合っているかについて話します。
- ② 私が読んだ記事によると、中野区の「スマホ教室」に参加するお年寄りの数は、去年の二倍になりました。
- ③ それに、高校生もお年寄りから地域の歴史を学んでいます。
- ④ ですから、この活動は、日本の人々が世代をこえたつながりを大切にしていることを示していると思います。

- ① **Clear introduction** that answers the prompt.
- ② **Specific finding** with an example from a source.
- ③ **Connectors** that organize ideas.
- ④ **Cultural insight** beyond simple facts.

Five habits for every speaking and writing task

1

Answer the question in your first sentence.

2

Use connectors to organize ideas.

3

Vary tenses and sentence structures.

4

Self-correct briefly, then keep going.

5

Use every second of speaking time.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Just **memorize** your presentation! (Careful.)



01 A memorized script

The presentation should sound natural. Know your findings well rather than reciting word for word.

02 Missing the PPR deadline

Without a submitted Personalized Project Reference, you won't have your outline during the presentation.

03 Too short

Stopping at 1:30 of a 3-minute presentation limits your score. Use the full time.

04 Ignoring the Q&A question

Answer exactly what is asked first; then elaborate.

05 Long silences

Use fillers in Japanese and keep going rather than stopping.

06 Only one tense

Showing past, present and future tenses demonstrates range.

07 Word-for-word translation

Think in phrases, not single words, to avoid unnatural sentences.

08 Wrong register in the email

Match formality to the recipient: a teacher needs polite forms; a friend can be casual.

09 Skipping notes while listening

Brief notes on names, numbers and opinions make audio questions much easier.

10 Cultural facts without insight

Explain what a practice or product shows about a community's perspectives.

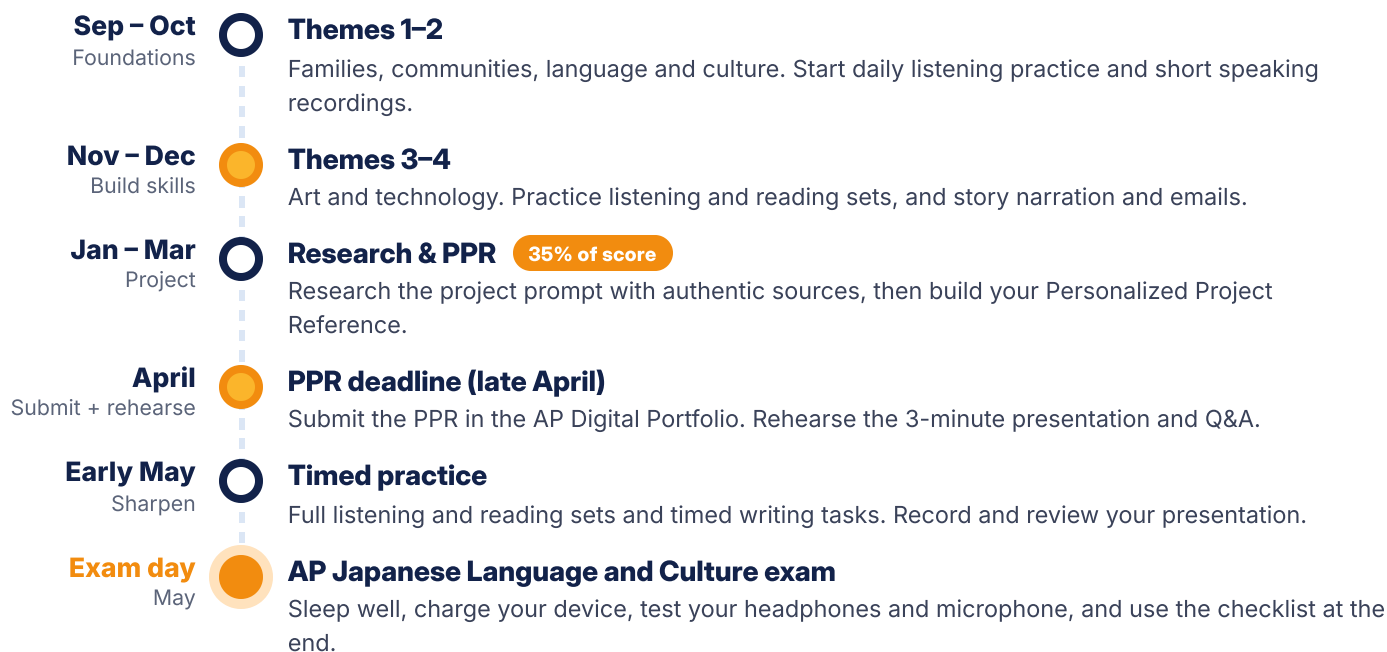
Quick self-check: can you speak about your project topic in Japanese for three minutes, using です/ます forms, connectors such as それに、でも、ですから, and at least one 〜によると to cite a source?

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Schedule your project research early so the PPR is ready well before the late-April deadline.



The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: one listening and one reading set	Name your weaker skill
3 weeks out	Daily: 10 min listening, one recorded presentation run	Use the full 3 minutes
2 weeks out	Full practice exam under timing	Finish every task
Final week	Light review: PPR, connectors, Q&A practice	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF 10 practice questions

Original reading and language questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Explanations on the answer page are in English. Give yourself **15 minutes**, then check page 11.

1 読解・主旨

文章を読んで、1～4の質問に答えてください。

最近、日本の多くの町で、高校生が地域のお年寄りにスマートフォンの使い方を教える活動が広がっています。東京の中野区では、毎月一回、公民館で「スマホ教室」が開かれています。「最初は教えるのが難しかったです」と高校二年生の田中さんはいいます。「でも、おばあさんたちと話すうちに、地域の歴史もたくさん教えてもらいました。」参加するお年寄りの数は、去年の二倍になりました。

ACT SAT GO オリジナル練習文

この文章は主に何について書かれていますか。

- A 新しいスマホの値段
- B 中野区の交通
- C 高校の入学試験
- D 高校生がお年寄りにスマホの使い方を教える活動

2 読解・内容

田中さんは最初どう感じましたか。

- A 教えるのは難しかった
- B 教えるのは簡単だった
- C つまらなかった
- D 全然疲れなかった

3 読解・内容

田中さんはお年寄りから何を教えてもらいましたか。

- A 料理
- B 英語
- C 地域の歴史
- D スマホの修理

4 読解・数字

参加するお年寄りの数はどうなりましたか。

- A 去年の半分
- B 去年の二倍
- C 去年と同じ
- D 去年の十倍

5 文法・経験

「日本へ行った__があります。」

- A こと
- B もの
- C ところ
- D ため

6 文法・逆接

「雨が降って__、試合は続きました。」

- A いるので
- B いても
- C いたら
- D いるから

7 助数詞

「本を三__買いました。」

- A 枚
- B 本
- C 冊
- D 匹

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

8 文法・比較

「この部屋はあの部屋____広いです。」

- A から
- B まで
- C ほど
- D より

9 メール・敬語

先生にメールを書くとき、どの表現が一番ていねいですか。

- A 明日、来る?
- B 明日、来るの?
- C 明日、いらっしゃいますか。
- D 明日、来いよ。

10 文化・視点

どの文が文化的な視点を一番よく表していますか。

- A 教室は毎月一回開かれる。
- B 多くの日本人は、世代をこえて助け合うことを大切にしている。
- C 公民館は駅の近くにある。
- D 教室には机が十ある。

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	D	The text describes high-school students teaching older residents how to use smartphones.
2	A	Tanaka says 「最初は教えるのが難しかったです」 (at first, teaching was difficult).
3	C・地域の歴史	Tanaka learned a lot about the local history from the older women.
4	B・去年の二倍	The number of participating seniors doubled from last year.
5	A・こと	Past tense + ことがある expresses past experience: "I have been to Japan."
6	B・いても	～ても means "even if / even though": the game continued even though it was raining.
7	C・冊	冊 is the counter for books.
8	D・より	A は B より + adjective means "A is more ... than B".
9	C	いらっしゃいますか is honorific (sonkeigo), appropriate for a teacher.
10	B	A perspective explains values (helping each other across generations), not just facts.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Read and listen to Japanese every day, and practice speaking for three minutes without stopping.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 72–75% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP Japanese Language and Culture, and about 43–47% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

72–75%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

43–47%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Your **PPR was submitted** in the AP Digital Portfolio before the late-April deadline
- ☐ **Headphones and microphone** tested for the speaking and listening sections
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review your PPR and practice the presentation once the night before

In the free-response tasks: answer every prompt directly, organize ideas with connectors, show a range of vocabulary and tenses, use the full time, and explain cultural perspectives, not just facts.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

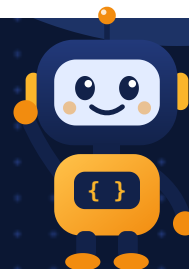
Aiming for a 5? Get a personal AP Japanese plan.

Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest units, review your practice responses, and give you a week-by-week plan to exam day in May.

Book a free diagnostic lesson →



Scan to book
www.actsatgo.com/consultation



Japanese conversation practice

Live 1-on-1 speaking sessions to build fluency for the presentation and Q&A.

Project & writing skills

Story narration and email coaching and research-skills support. Your project stays 100% your own work.

Listening & reading practice

Timed sets with authentic audio and texts, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

Web www.actsatgo.com

Email info@actsatgo.com

Phone [+1 \(945\) 391-6179](tel:+19453916179)

Share this guide

Know a classmate taking AP Japanese Language and Culture? Send them the link. It's free to download at www.actsatgo.com, along with guides for every other AP subject.

AP® and Advanced Placement® are trademarks registered by College Board, which is not affiliated with, and does not endorse, this product. Exam structure, weightings, question types and score information are summarized from publicly available College Board materials. Practice questions, sample responses and study plans are original works by ACT SAT GO and are not official exam questions or scoring guidelines. © ACT SAT GO. Free to share for personal, non-commercial study use.